Charlotte's Web

By E.B. White

Suggested Roles:

Actor: *Mr. Arable, Mr. Zuckerman, Narrator 1, Charlotte, Goose/Gander, Lamb, Templeton (the rat), Sheep, Fly, Mrs. Arable, Loudspeaker, Fair Official*
Actress: *Fern, Wilbur, Charlotte Narrator 2*

NOTE: *The role of Charlotte should be some combination of the 2 performers in both lines and physicality*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

TOGETHER: **(Pg 164)** After all, what's a life, anyway? We're born, we live a little while, we die.

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FERN: **(Pg 2-4)** Please don't kill it! It's unfair!

MR. ARABLE: *(Holding a very small pig)* Fern, you will have to learn to control yourself.

FERN: *(Yelling)* Control myself? This is a matter of life and death, and you talk about controlling myself.

MR. ARABLE: I know more about raising pigs than you do. A weakling makes trouble.

FERN: The pig couldn't help being born small, could it? If I had been very small at birth, would you have killed me?

MR. ARABLE: This is different.

FERN: I see no difference. This is the most terrible case of injustice I ever heard of.

MR. ARABLE: *(reconsidering)* All right, he's yours. *(Hands the pig over to Fern)* Start it on a bottle, like a baby. You'll see what trouble a pig can be. *(Strides off)*

FERN: *(Petting the little pig)* He's absolutely perfect! *(thinking)* **(Pg 7)** Wilbur . . . it's name is Wilbur!

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CHARLOTTE: *(Enters via her web)* Salutations! **(Pg 101)** *(She spins some web, obviously writing something)*

MR. ZUCKERMAN: **(Pg 115)** *(looks in awe as the spiderweb)* That pig is radiant!

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TOGETHER: **(Pg 164)** After all, what's a life, anyway?

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Charlotte's Web by E.B White is one of the all-time great classics of children's literature.*
ACTRESS: *It's gentle story with its kindly wisdom about friendship and love has survived and prospered for decades.*
ACTOR: *Why? Because its themes are universal and timeless:*
ACTRESS: *Growing up,*
ACTOR: *Death . . .*
ACTRESS: *And most importantly the power of friendship.*
ACTOR: *In the words of E.B. White, "Friendship is one of the most satisfying things in the world."*
TOGETHER: *Charlotte's Web by E.B. White*

MR. ARABLE: **(Pg 12)** He's got to go, Fern. *(attempts to lift Wilbur and cannot)* You have had your fun, but Wilbur is not a baby any longer. *(he drops him with a thump)* Tell your Uncle Homer you've got a pig you'll sell and see what he says.

NARRATOR 1: The next day Wilbur was taken from his home and went to live in a manure pile in the cellar of Zuckerman's barn.

WILBUR: **(Pg 16)** *(wandering outside; lonely and bored – he oinks)* There's never anything to do around here. **(Pg 28-29)** *(to the goose)* Will you play with me?

GOOSE: *(clucking and speaking rapidly and repetitively)* Sorry, sonny, sorry. I'm sitting on my eggs.

WILBUR: *(to the lamb)* Will you please play with me?

LAMB: *(Baa's disdainfully)* Certainly not. I don't play with pigs! Go play by yourself!

WILBUR: *(to Templeton, the rat)* Will you play with me, Templeton?

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TEMPLETON: Play? I hardly know the meaning of the word.

WILBUR: Well, it means to have fun, to frolic, to run and skip and make merry. *(he demonstrates)*

TEMPLETON: I never do those things! I prefer to spend my time eating, spying and hiding.

WILBUR: *(Heavy sigh and dejected oinking)* **(Pg 16)** I'm less than two months old and I'm tired of living. *(he sobs in an oinking manner)*

CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 31)** Do you want a friend, Wilbur? I'll be a friend to you. I've watched you all day and I like you!

WILBUR: *(sobbing subsides)* But I can't see you. Where are you? And who are you?

CHARLOTTE: I'm right up here. *(she descends, spinning her web)* **(Pg 35)** Salutations!

WILBUR: Salu-what?

CHARLOTTE: Salutations! It's my fancy way of saying hello! **(Pg 36-39)** Look up here in the corner of the doorway! I'm waving! *(she waves)* See me now?

WILBUR: Salutations! May I have your name?

CHARLOTTE: My name? My name is Charlotte.

WILBUR: I think you're beautiful.

CHARLOTTE: Well, I am pretty. There's no denying that. All spiders are rather nice-looking. *(she notices a fly trapped in her web)* Watch me wrap up this fly! *(Fly beats its wings furiously, buzzing)* First, I dive at him. *(She plunges on a silken thread)* Next, I wrap him up (She does so and the buzzing becomes muffled) Now I knock him out, so he'll be more comfortable. *(She bites the fly)* He'll make a perfect breakfast for me.

WILBUR: *(gasping)* You mean you eat flies! . . . Do they taste good?

CHARLOTTE: Delicious. I don't really eat them. I drink them. Drink their blood. I love blood!

SHEEP: **(Pg 49-51)** *(entering)* Hello! Seems to me you're putting on weight. You know why they're fattening you up, don't you?

WILBUR: No

SHEEP: Well, I don't like to spread baaaaad news, but they're going to kill you.

WILBUR: They're going to what?

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SHEEP: Kill you. Turn you into smoked bacon. All young pigs get murdered by the farmer as soon as the cold weather sets in. Christmastime . . . pig . . . ham . . . Kill you!

WILBUR: *(squealing and crying)* I don't want to be killed. I don't want to die! Is it true, Charlotte? Are they going to kill me when the cold weather comes?

CHARLOTTE: Well, the old sheep has been around this barn a long time. If she says they plan to kill you, I'm sure it's true. *(Wilbur wails)* Stop your crying! I can't stand hysterics. You shall not die.

WILBUR: What? Really? Who's going to save me?

CHARLOTTE: I am!

WILBUR: *(suspicious)* [But] how?

CHARLOTTE: That remains to be seen. **(Pg 63)** *(Deep in thought)* I'm working on it!

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FERN: **(Pg 105)** Charlotte is the best storyteller I ever heard

MRS. ARABLE: Fern, you know spiders don't tell stories. Spiders can't talk.

FERN: Charlotte can. She doesn't talk very loud, but she talks!

MRS. ARABLE: **(Pg 106-107)** Fern, I wish you would play outdoors instead of going to Uncle Home's barn. You're spending too much time in that barn. It isn't good for you to be alone so much.

FERN: Alone? My best friends are in the barn cellar! **(Pg 71)** I'm going to visit Wilbur!

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CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 75-76)** *(moodily thinking, then she comes up with an idea. She descends to the center of her web and begins to cut some of her lines. She starts weaving a message, snipping lines and repositioning others . . . as she works to create her masterpiece she hums or sings)* **(Pg 94)** Up we go! Attach! Descend! Whoa! Good! Now right and down and swing that loop around and around! Now in to the left! Attach! Climb! Repeat! O.K.! Good girl! *(When she is finished she celebrates and then exhausted, sleeps)*

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MR. ZUCKERMAN: **(Pg 78-80)** *(He and Fern are bringing food for the animals, he notices the web and stops dead in his tracks. He sets down his pail and rums his eyes – Fern stands in awe, unable to speak)* I'm seeing things! Some Pig! *(stares for a long time at Wilbur then drops to his knees in awe)* We have received a sign– a mysterious sign. A miracle has happened on this farm! We have no ordinary pig! SOME PIG!

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 84)** The news of the wonderful pig spread clear up to the hills and farmers came down in buggies to stand at Wilbur's pen, admiring the miraculous animal. They had never seen such a pig in their lives!

MR. ZUCKERMAN: **(Pg 96)** Lurvy! Phone the reporter on the Weekly Chronical and tell him what has happened. He may want to bring a photographer . . . There is to be no more cow manure thrown down into that pigpen. I want that pig to have clean, bright straw every day! Start building a crate for Wilbur. I have decided to take [him] to the County Fair! Zuckerman's Famous Pig!

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CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 86-87)** *(calls a meeting of all the animals)* I shall begin by calling the roll. Wilbur?

WILBUR: Here!

CHARLOTTE: Gander

GANDER: Here, here, here!

CHARLOTTE: Why do you have to repeat everything?

GANDER: It's my idio-idio-idosyncrasy!

CHARLOTTE: Sheep?

SHEEP: He-aa-aa!

CHARLOTTE: Templeton? *(no answer)* Templeton? *(no answer)* Well, I guess we can proceed without the rat. *(With great fanfare)* The message I wrote in my web, praising Wilbur has been received. The Zuckermans and everybody else has fallen for it. Zuckerman thinks Wilbur is an unusual pig and therefore he won't want to kill him and eat him. My trick will work and Wilbur's life can be saved.

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WILBUR: Hurray!

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WILBUR: **(Pg 115-116)** You're going with me, aren't you, Charlotte? I need you, Charlotte. You've just got to come!

CHARLOTTE: No, I believe I'd better stay home and get some egg laying done.

WILBUR: *(amazed)* I didn't know you could lay eggs. Why don't you come with me to the Fair Grounds and lay your eggs there?

CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 122)** [Then] I shall go, too. We can't tell what may happen at the Fair Grounds. Somebody's got to go along who know how to write. Pg 127 *(the geese cheer)*

****** **at the fair** ******

LOUDSPEAKER: **(Pg 130)** Attention, please! Will the owner of a Pontiac license number H-2439 please move your car away from the fireworks shed!

WILBUR: **(Pg 134-135)** *(Charlotte climbs to the rafters at the fair)* What do you see?

CHARLOTTE: There's a pig in the next pen and he's enormous! Much bigger than you are.

WILBUR: *(whimpers as tears come to his eyes)*

CHARLOTTE: He's not anywhere near as clean as you are, nor as pleasant. He's going to be a hard pig to beat, though, Wilbur, on account of his size and weight. But with me helping you, it can be done!

WILBUR: When are you going to spin a web?

CHARLOTTE: I shall be writing tonight for the last time. *(She starts weaving a message, snipping lines and repositioning others . . . as she works to create a new word, she hums or sings)* **(Pg 141)** Humble!

WILBUR: **(Pg 142)** *(humbly)* Charlotte, do you really thing Zuckerman will not keel me when the cold weather comes? Do you really think so?

CHARLOTTE: *(exhausted)* Of course. Tomorrow you will probably win a prize. The whole world will hear about you. You have nothing to fear, Wilbur.

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FAIR OFFICIAL: **(Pg 158)** Ladeez and gentlemen! On behalf of the Fair, I have the honor of awarding a special prize of 25 dollars and a handsome bronze medal to this pig. This radiant, this terrific, this humble pig. **(Pg 160)** *(he places the medal around Wilbur's neck. Wilber snorts and grins)*

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WILBUR: **(Pg 163-164)** *(after everyone had gone)* Charlotte! Charlotte! (he's taken aback by the silence) Do you feel alright?

CHARLOTTE: A little tired, perhaps. But peaceful . . . Nothing can harm you now.

WILBUR: *(with tears in his eyes)* Oh, Charlotte. Why did you do all this for me? I don't deserve it. I've never done anything for you.

CHARLOTTE: You have been my friend, Wilbur . . . this lovely world, these precious days. After all, what's a life anyway? We're born, we live a little while, we die.

WILBUR: **(Pg 165)** Charlotte, what are you talking about?

CHARLOTTE: I'm done for. In a day or two I'll be dead.

WILBUR: **(Pg 164)** Well, I'm no good at making speeches. I haven't got your gift for words. (sadly) But you have saved me, Charlotte, and I would gladly give my life for you – I really would.

CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 165)** I'm sure you would. And I thank you . . . **(Pg 171)** (whispers) Good-bye *(Charlotte dies)*

WILBUR: Charlotte? *(no response; Wilbur oinks sadly)*

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NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 184)** It's not often that someone comes along who is a true friend and a good writer. Charlotte was both.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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